

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD ☐UNUSUAL RECORD ☒

Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.

Species: Purple Finch (eastern race) | Carpodacus purpureus (purpureus)
(Vernacular Name) (Scientific Name)Date(s): 12/16 - 12/17 1989Number of birds seen: 1 Sex: ♀ Plumage: adultLocality: 1 mile S. of Plum Creek inlet at Chatfield SRA Elevation: 5600'Nearest town: Louville County: DouglasTime(s) observed: 8:30 a.m.Duration of observation (e.g. 1 sec., 5 min., etc.): 30 minutes

Other observers who saw the bird with you (give names, addresses, telephone numbers):

Joe Reiler 13040 W 16th Dr Golden, CO 80401 573-4451
 Bill Fink 7076 S. Miller Ct, Lakewood CO 80127 433-1220
 Warren Finch 455 Dover St Lakewood CO 80226 233-3372

Other observers who saw the bird independently (give names, addresses, telephone numbers)

found bird on 2/16 at Denver CEC
 DOUG Ward ?
 NORM Erthal 7761 Everett Way Arvada, CO 80005 424-6747
 Dick Schaffler 25 S. Indiana Pl Golden, CO 80401 278-8035

Light conditions (position of bird to light and shade, direction and strength of light):

Bright morning sun on cold winter day, seen from many angles during observation period.

Optical equipment used (e.g. power, types): Bushnell 10x40 CustomDistance, and how measured: as close as 15'If photographed, type of equipment and film: Pentax K-1000 camera w/ Sigma 400 mm lens, Fujichrome 100 filmWho else photographed the bird? no one else photographed it.

Describe the bird's behavior (e.g. flying, feeding, or habits used in identifying):

Slowly foraged, very methodically, on clematis berries on vines, about 6-10' above ground, then fed near ground on berries on low shrubs. Most of the time it foraged with black-capped chickadees. The bird was about 6" long, a medium-sized finch, larger than the chickadees it was with.

Describe in detail the bird's relative size, overall shape, plumage and color pattern. Include details of bill, wing and tail shape. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance to field guide descriptions and illustrations is not enough. Describe only what you actually observe in the field:

After many futile searches for Purple Finches that proved to be Cassins, I was very well prepared for what field marks to look for in a "real" Purple Finch. As my photo shows, this bird has an immaculately clear undertail covert area. All Cassins finches show streaks on the u-t coverts. The face is much more strikingly patterned than a Cassins Finch. The white supercilious broadens behind the eye, the ear coverts are dark, and especially noticeable is the broad white malar stripe below the beak. The beak was much more delicate than a Cassins Finch. The upper mandible was noticeably curved. A Cassins beak is longer, and more dagger like. An important field mark that I noticed, illustrated but not described in most books, is how white the underparts are

Description (continued):

Compared with Cassin's finches - The bolder streaks seem to contrast more with a white background. Cassin's finches are dingier - the base color of the breast + belly seems to be more beige (I have Cassin's finches at my feeder as I'm writing this). This bird was discernably smaller than Cassin's finches - maybe $\frac{1}{4}$ " to $\frac{1}{2}$ " shorter, which may make it look chunkier, because the tail is not as long. Field marks seen, which are less important to identification, are a brownish streaked back, dark legs and a light colored throat.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery, (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): Only once was a call given, a three part call note, fuller + richer sounding than a Cassin's, and very different from it. If I had heard more, I could describe it better.

Describe the general and specific habitat in which you observed the bird:

Riparian area along plum creek. Clematis vines were hanging on tall cottonwoods, and the bird usually fed on the clematis vines.

How did you eliminate similarly appearing species?

Known as finch by stout finchlike bill, behavior, habitat + experience.
Pine siskins differ greatly in terms of size, shape, call, appearance.
Cassin's finches differ as described above.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species?

Have seen purple finches in Illinois + on East Coast (purpureus race) and several times in California.

Observe Cassin's finches frequently at my own feeder and have seen them numerous times throughout Western mountains and on plains (during invasion years) near Denver.

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: - guide books not needed - but NGS guide is better than others for field marks important here.

b) after observation:

This report was written from reports made during ✓, after observation ✓ from memory ✓.

Date and time report was written: 1/26/90

Reporting observer: Dwane Nelson Signature: Dwane Nelson

Address: 31428 Burke Rd, Golden, CO 80403 303-642-7109

All reports will be maintained permanently at the address below:

Return to:

CURATOR, DEPARTMENT OF ZOOLOGICAL COLLECTIONS
DENVER MUSEUM OF NATURAL HISTORY
CITY PARK
DENVER, CO 80205

Dick Schottler

56-89-62

12/17/89 CHATFIELD STATE PARK

12:40 - 1:50 pm; clear, cold, calm

After getting a call from Duane W. Sagers, he and several others had seen it earlier in the day, & decided to go look for a Purple Finch found by Duane W. on the Xmas Hunt on 12/16. After looking for an hour, I finally spotted the finch. It appeared to be an adult ♀. Saw all field marks clearly and in

good light from approx 50 ft. away within 10x binoculars. The finch had a dark brown well-defined ear patch with a broad whitish stripe above and below the patch. Bill was relatively stubby, and upper mandible was noticeably curved and appeared darker than lower. Crown, nape and back were brown (with a yellowish tint). Side was noticeably streaked with dark brown streaks. Tail (above & below) was dark brown and was well-notched. Breast & belly were buffy white with heavy dark brown streaks (more distinct than house finch; heavier than Cassin's finch). Under tail coverts were well-seen and were clean white with

no brown streaks as expected on Cassin's finch. Bird was found along Plum Creek in the Southeast corner of the Park (just across tracks from S. Santa Fe Dr., ~ 3/4 mi north of Titan Rd). Finch appeared only slightly larger than Black-capped Chickadees. Watched the bird for 10 or minutes from about 1:40 to 1:50 pm. Overall impression was of a relatively small, chunky, short-tailed finch in contrast to slimmer, duller, house finch and larger Cassin's finch.